



HIGHER HEALTH

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QUALITY ASSURANCE POLICY



Policy on Quality Assurance

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Glossary

“Assessment” means the process used to identify, gather and interpret information and evidence against the required competencies in a qualification, part-qualification, or professional designation in order to make a judgement about a learner’s achievement. Assessment can be formal, non-formal or informal; assessment can be of learning already done, or towards learning to inform and shape teaching and learning still to be done.

“Curriculum” for the purposes of this Policy means requirements for learner achievement of a qualification or part-qualification in terms of knowledge, skills, and where relevant, work experience.

“e-Assessment” means any type of assessment that involves an electronic component and incorporates one or more of e-testing, e-portfolios and e-marking.

“Effective”, in the context of a quality management system, means a system that accomplishes its intended purpose.

“Efficient”, in the context of a quality management system, means a system that accomplishes its intended purpose while using time, effort and resources well; that is, the QMS provides value for money to the institution.

“e-learning” means a mode of teaching and learning that makes use of technology-mediated features.

“Evaluation of learning” means a process involving gathering evidence and making informed judgements about a learning programme, or module or component of a learning programme; or its curriculum, learning materials or assessment; or its impact on learners or society. Evaluation involves making a judgement about the worth, merit or impact of learning or a programme of learning.

“External assessment” means assessment developed by a qualified and competent person or body not directly involved in the development and/or delivery of the learning being assessed.

“External Quality Assurance (EQA)” means an external agency that ensures that institutions have Internal Quality Assurance (IQA) systems in place to manage the quality of their activities and educational provision. It also ensures that the programmes that they offer have been peer-reviewed to ensure that the provisioning meets the quality standards and criteria of the Quality Council on Trades and Occupations (QCTO).

“Final Integrated Supervised Assessment (FISA)” means a supervised final assessment for which assessment processes, tools, and results are recorded towards the achievement of a QCTO skills programme, conducted under examination conditions.

“Framework”, in the context of a quality management system, means the information that form the structure to simplify quality assurance practices and principles to attain sustainable improvement.

“Guidelines” means a document that indicates how a policy could reasonably be interpreted and implemented in the context of Higher Health.

“Integrated assessment” means assessment which involves all the differing types of assessment tasks required for a particular qualification, part-qualification, or professional designation, such as written assessment of theory and practical demonstration of competence. For skills programmes, the QCTO refers to this assessment as FISA.

“Internal Quality Assurance (IQA)” means the integrated institutional system, policies and processes used by an institution to manage the quality of its core and associated functions of learning and teaching.

“Learner” is an inclusive term referring to anyone learning, including pupils, students, apprentices, interns, learners in learnerships, people doing training, and people learning non-formally and informally as well as people enrolled for particular qualifications or part-qualifications, and people learning in contact, distance, and self-study contexts at all levels in the system.

“Moderation” in assessment means internal and external verification that an assessment system is credible and that assessors and learners behave in an ethical way; and that assessments are fair, valid, reliable and practicable.

“Policy” means the operational framework within which Higher Health functions, that acts as a guide to decision making.

“Procedures” means the operational processes required to implement the QA policy. Operating practices can be formal or informal, specific to a department, unit or directorate or applicable across the entire organisation.

“Process” means a series of actions or steps taken in order to achieve a desired result.

“Programme” means a purposeful and structured set of learning activities designed to enable a learner to meet the outcomes necessary for the award of a skills programme certificate.

“Quality” means meeting the requirements of nationally agreed outcomes and performance/assessment criteria, thus facilitating both provision and monitoring.

“Quality Assurance (QA)” means the processes of ensuring that specified standards or requirements for teaching, learning, education administration, assessment and the recording of achievements have been met. The OQSF further defines it as systems and procedures to ensure that occupational qualifications meet industry standards and requirements

“Quality Management System (QMS)” means the institutional arrangements for assuring, supporting, developing and enhancing, as well as monitoring the quality of learning, teaching and assessment.

“Standards” means the codes of practice for quality assurance used in post-school education, which skills development providers must consider and adhere to.

1. Background

Higher Health is a non-profit organisation focused on the health and wellness of the youth in the post-school education and training (PSET) sector. Higher Health's model of delivering health, wellness, and psycho-social services is to empower PSET learners to take charge of their health and wellness, through education and knowledge. Higher Health's programmes are intense, and were delivered in-person. It soon became apparent that more learners could be reached if the programmes were offered online, via e-learning. Learners also wanted recognition for attending the sessions. Higher Health therefore developed its e-learning Civic and Soft Skills Programme, which the QCTO accredited as a NQF Level 5 Skills Programme.

The Quality Assurance Policy therefore addresses Higher Health's face-to-face and online programmes.

2. Purpose

- a. Higher Health's Quality Assurance Policy aims to provide a framework for an efficient quality management system that includes:
 - i. The establishment and development of a quality assurance culture;
 - ii. The establishment and development of a functional institutional quality assurance and management system;
 - iii. The promotion of quality assurance and improvement actions at institutional level;
 - iv. The empowerment of staff in the execution and implementation of quality assurance systems, processes and mechanisms;
 - v. Co-ordination and monitoring of the quality assurance actions within the Programmes and Operations directorates;
 - vi. Accountability to Higher Health's QA partners, the Quality Council on Trades and Occupations (QCTO), and the Health and Welfare (HW) SETA; and
 - vii. The integration of quality assurance in all operational processes, including but not limited to governance, strategic planning, and fieldwork.
- b. Higher Health's Quality Assurance Policy's overarching purpose is to enhance learner success through quality assured learning and teaching, within the framework of Higher Health's Vision and Strategic Goals.

3. Legislative and Regulatory Framework

This policy must be read in conjunction with:

- I. QCTO OQSF Policy (2021);
- II. General Principles and Minimum Requirements on E-Assessment of Qualifications and Part Qualifications on the Occupational Qualifications Sub-Framework (OQSF); and
- III. Higher Health's policies and procedures relating to its e-learning and face-to-face offerings.

4. Scope and Application

- a. This policy applies to Higher Health's Operations and Programmes directorates, and the activities they perform in e-learning and face-to-face teaching; data collection; and reporting.
- b. Quality assurance processes will contain both External Quality Assurance (EQA) and Internal Quality Assurance (IQA) mechanisms to quality assure core and support functions and the functional units within Higher Health.

4.1 Teaching and Learning

- a. The learning and teaching focus includes quality assurance matters relating to Higher Health's e-learning curriculum development and delivery, and online learning and teaching material development.
- b. In addition, it includes the quality framework for face-to-face delivery of Higher Health's curriculum offered by peer mentors and peer educators at PSET institutions.
- c. External approval, accreditation, registration, recording and termination of Higher Health's programmes take place in accordance with the national policy requirements of the QCTO.
- d. Internal development, approval and modification/termination of skills programmes occur according to the Policy on Programme Development.
- e. Continuous assurance and enhancement and/or improvement of the quality of teaching and learning take place through regular focus groups of cohorts of learners; regular content reviews by the Curriculum content team; and through learner feedback on the e-learning platform.
- f. An evaluation of the entire curriculum takes place every three years, to confirm the currency of the information being taught.

4.2 Assessment

- a. Learner assessments are described in Higher Health's Policy on Assessments.
- b. Internal moderation of all final assessments takes place during each round of assessments, and is the responsibility of the Curriculum Programme team.

- c. A representative sample of all module assessments, and compulsory activities required for entry to the FISA assessment, is drawn and moderated for each cohort of learners. This moderation is conducted on an ongoing basis, to ensure that all requirements are met before a learner enrolls for the FISA assessments.
- d. External moderation of the learning achievements of learners is conducted by the appropriate staff within the HW SETA and QCTO.

4.3 Support services

- a. The units that support the work of the Operations and Programme teams, responsible for the e-learning or face-to-face offerings, are regularly audited by both Internal and External Audit.
- b. In addition, each donor conducts audits at least annually, against their specific criteria.
- c. Support services have standard operating procedures (SOPs) to enhance service quality, and to support quality monitoring.
- d. All internal and external audits are under the oversight of Higher Health's Audit, Risk and Finance Committee, that reports progress to the Board.

4 Principles

- a. Higher Health's Quality Assurance Policy is to ensure that the vision, strategic goals, governance, policies, frameworks, and structures, in the delivery of academic programmes ensure learner success.
- b. Quality assurance is not seen as an objective in itself but is aimed at the identification and addressing of quality gaps to assure a continuous cycle of planning, action, evaluation and improvement.
- c. Self-evaluation is accepted as the primary mechanism for quality assurance. It is the responsibility of each functional unit to establish and apply effective procedures for regular reflective self-evaluation and improvement.
- d. Self-evaluation is complemented and validated by external evaluation. External evaluation is conducted by HW SETA and QCTO, in terms of teaching and learning; internal and external auditors in terms of all support functions; and donors in terms of specific programmes.
- e. Quality assurance comprises the policies, procedures and mechanisms according to which Higher Health, or a specific unit or function, ensures that the required quality specifications and standards are maintained. These policies, procedures and mechanisms include continuous revision and monitoring activities to evaluate aspects such as suitability, efficiency, applicability and efficacy of all activities with a view to improvement.
- f. Quality improvement takes place through processes of continuous improvement of learner support- service functions and activities aimed at promoting excellence.

5. Roles and Responsibilities

- a. The responsibility for establishing and applying effective procedures for regular critical self-evaluation and for performing external evaluation for the academic and support service according to a specific cycle, rests with the Directors of Operations, Programmes and Finance.
- b. In particular, the Director of Operations is responsible for quality assurance involving the e-learning offering, and the Director of Programmes is responsible for quality assurance around the face-to-face curriculum offering.
- c. Quality Assurance around data collection is shared between the Director of Operations (M&E) and the Director of Programmes (fieldwork).
- d. The Director of Finance is responsible jointly with the other two Directors, for donor compliance reporting, and for coordinating all internal and external audits.
- e. The HW SETA and QCTO is responsible for external quality assurance on the online e-learning platform and accredited programme offering.